Demo case study: Plateful (PLTF), one squad through three rounds

A worked example of the Market Simulation night (150 teams: **50 Product, 50 Consulting, 50 Finance**), following one squad from the draw to the awards. Every number follows the competition rules (docs/archive/BRIEF-market-sim.md) and was checked by calculation. Use it in the briefing, in training before the event, and at the help desk.

Squad 12	Track	Team	Code	Job tonight
The company	Product	**Plateful**	P12	Builds the company, writes the pitch, survives the crisis
The advisers	Consulting	**Meridian Advisory**	C31	Earns a fee, writes the rescue plan with Plateful, makes market calls on two *other* companies
The investor	Finance	**Banyan Capital**	F08	Seeds Plateful, invests in the rescue, trades every other company

Two outsiders appear too: **Oakwood Fund** (F21), another fund, and **Keystone Partners** and **Lumen Advisory**, the two consultants the lottery assigned to cover Plateful.

Problem card picked: *Food and campus life: college canteens throw away 20–30% of cooked food every day, while students skip meals to save money.*

Round 1 · Build and IPO (21:00–00:30)

21:00 The draw

The lottery (seed + dice, checked against the published commitment) forms squad 12 and deals it three problem cards. Plateful has 10 minutes to pick one; it takes the canteen-waste card.

Who	What happens	Cash	Shares
Plateful	5,000 seed shares sold to Banyan at $10.00	**$0 → $50,000**	60,000 retained (locked)
Banyan	Buys the seed shares (squad lot)	$500,000 → **$450,000**	5,000 PLTF in its squad lot
Meridian	Assigned two *other* companies to cover (not PLTF)	$0	–
The exchange	35,000 PLTF shares to sell at the IPO		

21:10–22:30 Product: the pitch (≤400 words)

Plateful's pitch (excerpt):

> *Every evening, campus canteens bin 20–30% of what they cooked. Plateful sells that surplus as ₹40 "rescue boxes" that students reserve on an app between 8 and 9 pm. The canteen gets ₹25 a box for food it would throw away; we keep ₹15. Three canteens at our college already waste ~350 meals a day: at a 40% sell-through, that is 140 boxes and ₹2,100 a day for us before costs. Our advantage is the canteen contracts and the pickup routine, not the app.*

The judge reads it three times: **81, 83, 86** → the median **83** is in the **80–89** band → pitch tier **+10%**:

> **IPO price = $10.00 × 1.10 = $11.00.** The AI price also starts at **$11.00**.

Why 83 and not 90+: the problem and business model were sharp, but "our advantage is the contracts" is thin: any rival can sign the next canteen.

22:30–23:15 Reading and Q&A

The pitch book goes public. On the Q&A board a fund asks: *"What stops the canteen keeping the ₹25 by selling boxes itself?"* Plateful answers (≤100 words): the app brings the buyers and the payment; the canteen has neither.

Consulting, call 1 (due 23:15, baseline = IPO price $11.00, judged at the round 4 clearing):

- Keystone Partners: **BUY** PLTF.
- Lumen Advisory: **SELL** PLTF.

23:15–23:30 The IPO (Finance)

Funds bid for the 35,000 IPO shares (max 4,000 each; Banyan cannot bid on its own squad company). Total requests: **52,000 shares** → oversubscribed → every request is scaled by 35,000 ÷ 52,000, rounded **down** to 10 shares.

> Oakwood requested 4,000 → 4,000 × 35,000 ÷ 52,000 = 2,692.3 → **2,690 shares** for **$29,590**. The money goes to the exchange, not to Plateful.

23:30–00:30 Trading rounds 1–4

Each round: net = shares bought − shares sold; the price moves 1% per 1,000 net shares (capped at ±10%); every order fills at the new price.

Round	Net shares	Change	PLTF price
1	+4,200	+4.2%	$11.00 → **$11.46**
2	+2,500	+2.5%	→ **$11.75**
3	−1,800	−1.8%	→ **$11.54**
4	+600	+0.6%	→ **$11.61**

Call 1 judged: $11.61 > $11.00 → Keystone's BUY is **correct (+$2,500)**; Lumen's SELL is wrong.

Round 2 · Crisis and rescue (00:30–03:00)

00:30 The crisis card: ***Regulation***

> *New food-safety rules: cooked food may be resold only within 2 hours of cooking and must be kept below 5 °C until pickup. Fines start next month.*

Trading halts; both prices fall **15%**:

	Before	× 0.85	After
Market price	$11.61		**$9.87** ← the post-crisis price
AI price	$11.00		**$9.35**

The rescue-deal price band is now **50%–100% of $9.87 = $4.94–$9.87** per share.

00:30–01:05 The fee (Product ↔ Consulting)

Meridian proposes **$15,000 cash + 1,500 shares** (shares count at the IPO price: 1,500 × $11.00 = $16,500). Total **$31,500**: inside $10,000–$35,000 and under the 3,000-share limit. Both confirm at 00:52 (without agreement, a $22,500 cash fee would move automatically at 01:05).

	Cash	Shares
Plateful	$50,000 → **$35,000**	60,000 → **58,500**
Meridian	**$15,000**	**1,500** fee shares

00:30–02:45 The deal (all three teams)

Banyan offers **$72,000** (allowed: $40,000–$80,000) at **$8.00** a share (81% of the post-crisis price). shares = floor($72,000 ÷ $8.00) = **9,000**; cash moved = 9,000 × $8.00 = **$72,000**. All three teams sign at **02:10**, before the 02:45 cut-off, so Meridian earns the **$5,000 deal bonus**.

	Cash	Shares
Plateful	$35,000 → **$107,000**	58,500 → **49,500** retained
Banyan	−$72,000	squad lot 5,000 → **14,000** (cost $50,000 + $72,000 = **$122,000**)

Why $8.00? At $4.94 Banyan would get 14,574 shares for the same money, taking 5,574 more from Plateful, and a deal at ≤55% of the post-crisis price with a weak plan raises a collusion flag. At $9.87 Banyan gets only 7,294 shares and may refuse to sign, and **without a signed deal the plan is capped at 50**.

00:30–03:00 The rescue plan (Product + Consulting, ≤500 words)

Plan (excerpt):

> *Move pickup to 7:30–8:30 pm so every box is sold within 2 hours of cooking. Use $30,000 of the deal money for 12 insulated chillers (₹2.1 lakh, payback in 9 weeks). Raise the box to ₹45; the canteen still gets ₹25. Month 1: two canteens compliant; month 3: all three, 160 boxes a day; break-even in month 4. Risk: inspectors reject the chillers. Plan B: partner with the college's central kitchen, which already has cold storage.*

Submitted at **02:51** (a late plan scores 0). Meanwhile trading continues in rounds 5–12; at the round 12 clearing PLTF is at **$9.40**.

Round 3 · Verdicts, flash news and the close (03:00–05:40)

03:30 Verdict on the plan

Judge runs **74, 77, 79** → median **77** → the **70–79** band → plan tier **+10%** on both prices (the deal was signed, so no cap):

	Before	× 1.10	After
Market price	$9.40		**$10.34**
AI price	$9.35		**$10.29**

Meridian's plan bonus: $500 × (77 − 50) = **$13,500**.

Call 2 (due 03:40, baseline $10.34, judged after the flash tier): Keystone **BUY**, Lumen **SELL**.

04:00–04:20 Flash news

The 04:00 bulletin hits every company: *"Cooking-gas prices rise 30% overnight."* Plateful answers in 86 words: cheaper evening batches and a ₹5 surcharge on boxes for two weeks. Score **74** → the **70–79** flash band → **+5%**, applied after round 17 clears (PLTF at $11.20):

	Before	× 1.05	After
Market price	$11.20		**$11.76**
AI price	$10.29		**$10.80** ← final AI price

Call 2 judged: $11.76 > $10.34 → Keystone's BUY **correct**, Lumen's SELL wrong. **Call 3** (due 04:30, baseline $11.76, judged at the closing price): Keystone **SELL**, Lumen **BUY**.

05:00 The close

Rounds 20 and 21 clear at **$11.90** and **$12.30**.

- Market close = ($11.90 + $12.30) ÷ 2 = **$12.10**
- AI price = **$10.80** ($11.00 → $9.35 → $10.29 → $10.80)
- **Closing price = ($12.10 + $10.80) ÷ 2 = $11.45**

Call 3 judged: $11.45 < $11.76 → Keystone's SELL **correct**. Keystone went 3 for 3 on PLTF (**$7,500**); Lumen 0 for 3.

Final values

Team	Calculation	Final
Plateful (Product)	49,500 retained × $11.45 + $107,000 cash	**$673,775**
Meridian (Consulting)	$15,000 fee cash + $13,500 plan bonus + $5,000 deal bonus + $10,000 from its own calls (4 of 6 correct) = $43,500 cash, plus 1,500 fee shares × $11.45 = $17,175	**$60,675**
Banyan (Finance), squad lot only	14,000 × $11.45 = $160,300 against a cost of $122,000	**+$38,300** on the lot

Plateful's turnaround: $11.45 ÷ $9.87 = **1.16×**. Banyan's full result also counts every trade it made in the other 49 companies (it is ranked on its return on $500,000).

What each track should take away

Product. Every share you hand over is value you lose at the close: Plateful gave 1,500 (fee) + 9,000 (deal) and still finished at $673,775 because the plan held the price up. Writing is your only direct lever: the pitch set the IPO price, the plan added 10%, the flash 5%.

Consulting. The plan earns you the most ($13,500 here; a 90 would have been $20,000). Get the deal signed by 02:45 for the $5,000 bonus *and* to avoid the plan cap of 50. Calls are $2,500 each: read the news and the plans, not the mood of the room.

Finance. Price the rescue so all three teams sign: too cheap raises a flag and starves the company; too dear and the plan is capped. The closing price is half the AI price, so the market can over-shoot ($12.10 vs $10.80): the written scores pull everyone back towards it.